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When Does Retirement Make Sense for You?

When I was a student at Occidental College, I helped the college data center design a new information system. As part of my job I had to meet with the college administrative heads and ask about their data needs.

My most memorable meeting was with Clancy, head of the food service. In 1986 I heard that Clancy had come out of retirement to whip the Occidental kitchen back into shape. But when I was a student there in 1970 she was already a legend. She kept thousands of us fed and healthy at a cost we could afford. Most important, she served things we liked. Students are a thankless lot. But most of us at the time agreed that Clancy was "all right."

I finally went to meet this sturdy, stout, gray-haired woman. After introducing myself I said something like, "We're computerizing the college's data systems. [Even back then I had a certain facility for using nouns as verbs.] We've already done the registrar and alumni offices. Now we want to start programming the food service."

Clancy's eyes bored through me like a locomotive through a mountain tunnel. "Just remember one thing, young man." Then she paused and, very slowly, emphasized each word. "I'm against all change."